Party and the Bahujan Samaj Party's Mayawati, as Rahul's yatra wended its way into the state in the new year. In Akhilesh's case, even that came after a bit of heated verbal jousting between the two leaders. Beyond the north, at least two Opposition CMs—West Bengal's Mamata Banerjee and Telangana's K. Chandrashekar Rao—appear unwilling to accept Congress primacy. Delhi's Arvind Kejriwal, of course, is a natural rival. It is in this space that Nitish's intervention can play a role, since he has an access to all sides here.

Since August 9, 2022, when Nitish dumped the BJP and linked up with the RJD, Congress and four other parties to form a new government in Bihar, he has been pitching for a broad-based Opposition unity, with the Grand Old Party taking its old central role: a 'Congress-yukt' model. "Nitish's idea of Opposition unity always accorded centrality to the Congress," says a top JD(U) leader, recalling how it was Rahul that the Bihar CM had chosen to meet as the first prominent Opposition leader within weeks of going over to the anti-BJP side. That September 5 meeting—and the subsequent one on September 25, where he and RJD patriarch Lalu Yadav met Sonia Gandhi—amounted to not only a bilateral overture, but a message to others, he adds. But this endorsement is not without an expectation of a matching initiative from the Congress. He wants its leadership to take the lead in nudging other parties onto one platform—something he has been urging since those meetings. The two Bihar leaders had asked Sonia to take an initiative, as the old UPA chairperson. She had promised to do so, but is yet to make any discernible move, and the GOP seemed to get caught up in Rahul's yatra, which kicked off on September 7. That left a vacuum in the space for unity-making, till it came about almost as an afterthought before the BJY's UP leg.

Nitish has from the outset said he is neither willing nor inclined to aspire to the PM's job, but since he's lending his stature and experience to the process of Opposition unity, he expects the Congress to add some formality to the task. In his mind, it is already taking on a shape. "The Congress may consider reviving the now-defunct UPA. Nitish can be given the responsibility of convenor—a role George Fernandes once played for the NDA—to give him the locus to reach out to other regional chieftains," says the party leader.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

A FORMAL DISTANCE
Akhilesh Yadav has been ambivalent towards Congress overtures

Another JD(U) leader explains why Nitish wants the Congress to get serious on the war preparations. "The BJP, at its peak in 2019, won only 303 seats. Contrary to the perception it exudes of being a pan-India behemoth, as much as 87 per cent of those seats—262 out of 303—came from just 12 states, including Bihar. Poll statistics make it clear it's just a top-heavy party overwhelmingly dependent on these 12 states. If we shake them there, they will be shaken for good," he says. And the Congress, with or without allies, is in direct contest with the BJP in nine out of these 12: Karnataka (BJP: 25 seats), Madhya Pradesh (28), Rajasthan (24), Chhattisgarh (9), Assam (9), Bihar (17), Gujarat (26), Haryana (10), Maharashtra (23), UP (62), Bengal (18) and Jharkhand (11). "In the first four, the Congress is a genuine match, and to a degree in Haryana, while it's a formidable adversary with allies in Maharashtra and Jharkhand," says the leader. "The fact is, the BJP's 2019 peak was about 38 per cent votes. Flip the detail: it means 62 per cent voted against the BJP. A part of our idea is to consolidate these votes."

NITISH'S IDEA OF OPPOSITION UNITY ALWAYS ACCORDED CENTRALITY TO THE CONGRESS

Unlike leaders like Kejriwal who may prefer to wait and grow bigger to become the Opposition's face at a later stage, instead of backing the Congress in 2024, Nitish seems to have his eyes set on the here and now. Having already declared Tejashwi Yadav as the leader of the Bihar grand alliance for the 2025 assembly polls, he doesn't wish to settle for any half-hearted measures for 2024. He had kickstarted his outreach as soon as he formed the new government in Bihar—having met, besides Rahul and Sonia, also Kejriwal, ex-Karnataka CM H.D. Kumaraswamy, Left leaders Sitaram Yechury and D. Raja, NCP boss Sharad Pawar, Akhilesh and INLD boss Omprakash Chautala. Besides, KCR visited Patna to meet him. But if September raised some hopes of an Opposition alliance forming, the next three have elapsed without much progress.

Sources close to Nitish say he expected the Congress to make a move at least after Mallikarjun Kharge took over in October. Having kept his patience for two months, he voiced his disappointment at least twice last month. It was conspicuous when he said on December 11: "*Mera batwa maanenge to ee haar jaayenge, mera baat log nahin maanenge to hum kya karenge, humko kya hai* (If they listen to me, the BJP will lose. If they don't, what can I do...I have no stakes)." Again, on December 25, when reporters quizzed him about Rahul's yatra, his response was a laconic "I don't know." A week later, his Rahul endorsement—the most decisive by any Opposition chief minister—seems like a magnanimous ultimatum. ■